



Continuing with our series on Emacs, in this article, let's explore basic buffer navigation, formatting, and help commands.

GNU Emacs is the most widely used variant of a family of text editors that is extremely extensible. Since its creation in the 1970s, through its continued development right up to the current moment, Emacs has evolved into a collection of over 2,000 built-in commands that allow users to combine them into macros to automate work. Featured here are some of them for readers to explore.

Buffers

You can view a list of buffers in GNU Emacs using the `C-x C-b` command and can switch to a buffer using the `C-x b` shortcut. The default list of buffers as seen in GNU Emacs 24.3.1 on Ubuntu 14.10 is shown below:

```
CRM Buffer      Size Mode      File
.  *scratch*    191 Lisp Interaction
* *Messages*   485 Fundamental
% *Completions* 264 Completion List
% *Help*       1855 Help
```

In order to kill (close) a buffer, you can use the `C-x k` key combination. If you have multiple buffers that you would like to close, you can use the `M-x kill-some-buffers` command, which will prompt you for a confirmation for every buffer. You can also rename a buffer using the `M-x rename-buffer` command. If you would like to save the buffer contents to a file, you can use `C-x s`, and it will prompt you with many options before proceeding to save the file. You can also save a modified buffer using `C-x C-s`.

Navigation

It is important to learn how to use the Emacs navigation

commands instead of the arrow keys. When you learn to use macros, you will find it useful to automate steps. A summary of the basic navigation shortcuts are given in the following table:

Command	Meaning
<code>C-f</code>	Move forward one character
<code>C-b</code>	Move backward one character
<code>M-f</code>	Move forward one word
<code>M-b</code>	Move back one word
<code>C-p</code>	Move to the previous line
<code>C-n</code>	Move to the next line
<code>C-a</code>	Move to the beginning of the line
<code>C-e</code>	Move to the end of the line

You can scroll down a buffer using `C-v`, and scroll up using the `M-v` shortcut. If you would like to move to the beginning of a file, use the `M-<` command. You can move to the end of a file using the `M->` shortcut.

In order to move the cursor to a specific line, use the `M-x goto-line` or `M-g g`. If you would like to position the contents where the cursor is located to the centre of the screen, you can use `C-l`. If you want to repeat a command 'n' (where 'n' is an integer) number of times, you can use `M-n` followed by the command. You can also use `C-u n`, but if you don't specify 'n' here, the next command, by default, will be executed four times.

Clipboard

You can delete a character where the cursor is located using `C-d`. To remove a word, you can use `M-d`. You can remove text from the cursor position till the end of the line using